

memory of choice for keeping and accessing data, remains but there's been a drastic change in architecture and speeds. While yesteryear's memory modules could make do with data access that happened one way at a time, today's architecture is pushing the limits, and using dual-channel technology, data can now be written and read from memory at the same time, thereby leading to performance gain.

The Motherboard: From the time of the PC XT to today, this is one component that has undergone massive changes with each generation. The one component that has remained on the motherboard for the past three generations is the PCI slot; though it has undergone revision changes, its appearance hasn't changed. It's still white, and is still featured on the spanking new PCI-e generation of motherboards.

The Hard Drive: This component used to be called a Winchester disk when it was first launched. A secondary storage medium, today's hard drives can be compared to mainframe data storage systems that were available until a few years ago. Capacities of drives used to range from 60 MB to 240 MB; drives today have capacities more like 250 GB and 500 GB. Rpm speeds were much lower than what we see today. And costs were far higher than the present rates. In fact the first hard drive for micro-computers, introduced by Seagate in 1980, the ST506, cost approximately \$1,000 (Rs 10,000 back then) and its storage capacity was, can you believe it, a measly 5 MB!

We haven't talked about the video card in this list of hardware, as there is an entire section on video card later in the chapter. Talking about the video card here will not justify the position that it commands today's gaming scenario.

Gaming Requirements Of Today

The games we played in the past did not require us to get dedicated gaming equipment. However, if you've ever played an arcade game, you would know how much easier it is to handle a spaceship using a joystick rather than a keyboard. This is what we are talk-